YEAR 1 · UNIT 5 · DAYS 94-116

The Mosaic Covenant I: Exodus

Exodus 1-24

God redeems before he commands. The pattern of grace establishing law.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery."

EXODUS 20:2

Psalms 106, 77, 114, and 105:26-45 retell the exodus as worship.

UNIT 5

In this unit

WEEK 14

94	Exodus 1:1-2:25	*Reading*
95	Exodus 3:1-4:31	*Reading*
96	Exodus 3:13-15; Exodus 34:5-7	*Doctrine*
97	Psalm 106:1-23	*Psalm*
98	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 15

99	Exodus 5:1-7:25	*Reading*
100	Exodus 8:1-9:35	*Reading*
101	Exodus 10:1-11:10	*Reading*
102	Exodus 12:1-13:16	*Reading*
103	Exodus 13:17-14:31	*Reading*
104	Psalm 106:24-48	*Psalm*
105	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 16

106	Exodus 15:1-27	*Reading*
107	Psalm 77	*Psalm*
108	Psalm 114	*Psalm*
109	Exodus 16:1-18:27	*Reading*
110	Exodus 19:1-20:26	*Reading*
111	Exodus 20:1-17; Matthew 5:17-48; Romans 13:8-10	*Doctrine*
112	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 17

113	Exodus 21:1-22:31	*Reading*
114	Exodus 23:1-24:18	*Reading*
115	Psalm 105:26-45	*Psalm*

DAY 94 · WEEK 14

Exodus 1:1-2:25

Israel enslaved; Moses born, hidden, and called

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 1:1-2:25. Four hundred years pass between the end of Genesis and the opening of Exodus, and the chapters you are reading cover the start of Israel's slavery and the birth of its deliverer. Read the story with the Genesis promises in mind, and notice how often God works through small, hidden acts of courage.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Genesis ended with Joseph's family safe in Egypt. Exodus begins with a sentence that sounds like a continuation: "These are the names of the sons of Israel." But the world has changed. Joseph's generation has died, and the descendants of Jacob have become a great nation within Egypt's borders. That is the fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham to make him a great nation (Genesis 12:2). It is also the cause of Egypt's fear. The book of Exodus is the second book of the Law, and it tells how God turned a family of slaves into a covenant people. Everything in the Bible that speaks of redemption looks back to what happens here.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people of Israel are "fruitful and increased greatly; they multiplied and grew exceedingly strong, so that the land was filled with them" (1:7). This echoes the creation command in Genesis 1:28.
2. "Now there arose a new king over Egypt, who did not know Joseph" (1:8). He fears that Israel will join Egypt's enemies and enslaves them (1:9-11).
3. The more they were oppressed, "the more they multiplied and the more they spread abroad" (1:12).

4. The midwives Shiphrah and Puah "feared God" and did not obey Pharaoh's order to kill the Hebrew boys (1:17).
5. God "dealt well with the midwives" (1:20), and Pharaoh then commands that every newborn Hebrew boy be thrown into the Nile (1:22).
6. A Levite woman hides her baby son for three months, and then puts him in a basket among the reeds (2:1-3). The word for "basket" is the same word used for Noah's ark.
7. Pharaoh's daughter finds him, takes pity, and names him Moses, "because I drew him out of the water" (2:10). His sister Miriam arranges for his own mother to nurse him (2:7-9).
8. Moses, as an adult, kills an Egyptian who is beating a Hebrew, and flees to Midian when it becomes known (2:11-15).
9. In Midian, he marries Zipporah and has a son named Gershom, "I have been a sojourner in a foreign land" (2:21-22).
10. "God heard their groaning, and God remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac, and with Jacob. God saw the people of Israel, and God knew" (2:24-25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening chapters of Exodus are told in a quiet way. God is not named as acting until the last verses of chapter 2. Until then, the story is carried by people: a frightened king, two midwives, a mother and a sister, and a princess. The reader is invited to see how God's purposes move forward even when he seems to be absent. It is a pattern you have seen before, in Joseph's story, and in Job's.

Pharaoh is a portrait of power that fears. He has the largest empire in the world, and he is afraid of a population of slaves. His answer is violence, first by labor and then by murder. But every plan he makes fails. The more he oppresses, the more Israel grows. The Nile that he orders the babies thrown into becomes the place where a rescuer is drawn out. The book is teaching you early that God's promises cannot be defeated by the schemes of rulers.

The midwives are among the quiet heroes of Scripture. They "feared God" more than they feared Pharaoh. The fear of God, as you learned in Job 28:28, is the beginning of wisdom, and it is also the source of courage. They have no power, and they do something small: they let the boys live. God honors them and gives them families of their own. Their story is a reminder that obedience to God sometimes means quiet resistance to unjust authority.

Moses' own story is full of echoes. A baby is put in a floating basket, the same word as Noah's ark, and is saved through water. He is raised in the house of the oppressor, and he is then a fugitive. At first he tries to rescue his people by his own strength, with violence, and it fails. He needs to be taught a better way. Forty years in the wilderness will do that.

But the center of the passage is the last two verses. God hears, remembers, sees, and knows. These are four verbs, and the first three recall what God does in covenant. "Remembered his covenant" does not mean that God had forgotten. It means that he is now acting on what he promised. The slavery of Israel has not made God forget Abraham. It has set the stage for him to keep his word.

STEP 5

Connection

Stephen retells this story in Acts 7:17-29, and Hebrews 11:23-27 praises the faith of Moses' parents and of Moses himself. Matthew presents the infant Jesus escaping Herod's murder of the boys in a way that echoes this chapter (Matthew 2:13-18). Paul says that God "chose what is weak in the world to shame the strong" (1 Corinthians 1:27), and Moses is an early example.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a place where you feel powerless. Remember the midwives. A small act of faithfulness is not wasted.

Notice how often God's actions in this story are hidden. If you are in a season where you cannot see God working, ask him to show you where he is, and trust that he has heard.

Pray for people who are living under oppression today, and ask what you could do to help.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he hears groaning and remembers his covenant.
- Ask for courage to fear him more than anyone with power.
- Pray for someone who is crying out today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

“God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you.”

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 95 · WEEK 14

Exodus 3:1-4:31

The burning bush; the divine name I AM; Moses commissioned

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 3:1-4:31. This is the call of Moses. Read it slowly. Pay special attention to what God says about himself, and to each excuse that Moses offers and how God answers it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Forty years have passed since Moses fled Egypt. He is now eighty, a shepherd in the desert of Midian, and everything he once hoped to be has been left behind. Then, one day, he sees a bush burning that is not consumed. What follows is one of the most important encounters in the Bible. God reveals his name, announces his plan, and commissions an unwilling servant. Almost everything that comes later in the Old Testament, the exodus, the covenant, the law, the prophets, grows out of this scene.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses comes to Horeb, “the mountain of God,” and sees “the angel of the LORD” in a flame of fire in the midst of a bush that is not consumed (3:1-2).
2. God calls, “Moses, Moses!” and tells him not to come near, “for the place on which you are standing is holy ground” (3:4-5).
3. God says, “I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob” (3:6). Moses hides his face.
4. “I have surely seen the affliction of my people who are in Egypt and have heard their cry…and I have come down to deliver them” (3:7-8).
5. Moses asks, “Who am I that I should go to Pharaoh?” God answers, “But I will be with you” (3:11-12).

6. Moses asks for God's name. God says, "I AM WHO I AM...Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you" (3:14).
7. God adds, "The LORD, the God of your fathers...has sent me to you. This is my name forever, and thus I am to be remembered throughout all generations" (3:15).
8. Moses offers objections: they will not believe me (4:1), I am not eloquent (4:10). God gives him signs, and reminds him, "Who has made man's mouth?" (4:11).
9. God is angry at Moses' final request, "Oh, my Lord, please send someone else" (4:13), but provides his brother Aaron as a spokesman (4:14-16).
10. God tells Moses to say to Pharaoh, "Israel is my firstborn son...Let my son go that he may serve me" (4:22-23). The people believe and worship (4:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The bush that burns without being consumed is a picture of God himself. Fire is a common symbol of God's holy presence, and here it burns without destroying what it touches. God's holiness is dangerous, and yet it does not have to be fatal. That is a hint of what is to come in the tabernacle, and in Christ.

The ground is holy because God is there, not because of anything about the place. Moses is told to take off his sandals. It is a physical way of saying that he is in the presence of someone infinitely greater than he is. Many of the Bible's accounts of meeting God begin this way, and they end with someone who has been changed.

Now look at how God introduces himself. First as the God of the fathers: Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. He is the God who made promises. Then as the God who sees, hears, knows, and comes down. These are verbs of nearness, and they are what Israel needs to hear. Then God sends Moses, and the sending is hard, because Moses does not want to go.

Moses' objections are worth looking at one by one. "Who am I?" is a question of worthiness, and God does not answer it by telling Moses that he is great. He answers by saying, "I will be with you." The solution to his smallness is God's presence. "What is your name?" is a question about God's character, and the answer is the most mysterious in Scripture. "They will not believe me" is a question of credibility, and God gives signs. "I am not eloquent" is a question of ability, and God replies, "Who has made man's mouth?" Every excuse is met with a reminder of who God is.

The name "I AM WHO I AM" has been studied for thousands of years. It seems to say that God is self-existent: he does not depend on anything else, and he simply is. It also seems to say that he will be what he will be: he is free, and he will show himself faithful. The name

connected to it, the LORD (Yahweh), becomes the personal name by which Israel knows him. You will see that name in capital letters throughout your English Bible. Tomorrow's doctrinal day will look at it more closely.

Finally, notice what God calls Israel: "my firstborn son." This is the language of family. Before the law, before the covenant at Sinai, God says that Israel is his son. Redemption is not a business arrangement. It is the rescue of a child.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus uses the burning bush to teach about the resurrection (Mark 12:26-27). He also speaks the divine name of himself: "Before Abraham was, I am" (John 8:58), and the "I am" sayings in John (6:35; 8:12; 10:11; 11:25; 14:6). Hebrews 3:1-6 compares Moses and Jesus as faithful servants. Paul says that God's "power is made perfect in weakness" (2 Corinthians 12:9).

STEP 6

Application

Take off your shoes, so to speak. Before you pray this week, spend a minute simply remembering who you are speaking to.

Identify your own list of excuses: "Who am I? What if they do not listen? I am not good enough." Read God's answers to Moses as answers to you.

Say aloud, "I will be with you." If you can, write it on a card where you will see it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for being holy and near.
- Tell him where you feel inadequate for what he asks, and ask him for his presence.
- Ask him to help you go where he sends and speak what he gives.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

"God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you."

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 96 · WEEK 14

Exodus 3:13-15; Exodus 34:5-7

The Existence and Attributes of God

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 3:13-15 and Exodus 34:5-7. The first passage is the revelation of God's name at the burning bush. The second is God's own description of his character, given after Israel's sin with the golden calf. Read them together, and ask what each says about who God is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the first doctrinal pause in Unit 5. Each time you meet one of these days, you step back from the story and ask what the Bible teaches. Today the topic is the most basic one: who God is. You have just read the call of Moses, where God revealed his name and described himself as the God of the fathers. Now you look at the two most important self-descriptions in the Old Testament. One tells you that God exists on his own. The other tells you what God is like.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses asks, "If I come to the people of Israel and say to them, The God of your fathers has sent me to you, and they ask me, What is his name? what shall I say to them?" (3:13).
2. God answers, "I AM WHO I AM" and "I AM has sent me to you" (3:14).
3. He then says, "The LORD, the God of your fathers…has sent me to you. This is my name forever" (3:15).
4. In Exodus 34, Moses is on Mount Sinai after Israel's sin with the golden calf. The LORD passes before him and proclaims, "The LORD, the LORD" (34:6).
5. God describes himself as "a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness" (34:6).

6. He “keeps steadfast love for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin” (34:7).

7. But he is also one “who will by no means clear the guilty, visiting the iniquity of the fathers on the children and the children’s children, to the third and the fourth generation” (34:7).

8. Moses quickly bows his head and worships (34:8).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

What is God like? The Bible’s answer starts with what theologians call his “aseity,” from a Latin phrase meaning “from himself.” God has life in himself. He does not need anything or anyone. He was not created, and nothing sustains him. When God says, “I AM WHO I AM,” he is saying, among other things, that he is the one who simply is. Everything else depends on him, and he depends on nothing. This is the foundation for all that follows. It means that God is not one more thing in the universe, even the greatest of them. He is the Creator of everything that is not himself.

The name given at the burning bush, written in English Bibles as “the LORD” in capital letters, is God’s personal name, Yahweh. It is related to the verb “to be,” and it speaks of his eternal, unchangeable presence. He is faithful to his promises because he does not change. Malachi 3:6 says, “For I the LORD do not change; therefore you, O children of Jacob, are not consumed.” James 1:17 speaks of the “Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shadow due to change.” This is what theologians call God’s immutability. It does not mean that God is cold or distant. It means that his character and purposes are utterly reliable.

Then there is the self-description in Exodus 34:6-7, which becomes the most quoted passage in the Old Testament. Over and over, in the Psalms, the Prophets, and Nehemiah, writers return to these words (Numbers 14:18; Nehemiah 9:17; Psalm 103:8; Joel 2:13; Jonah 4:2). It is God’s own summary of his character. Notice how it starts: with mercy, grace, patience, steadfast love, and faithfulness. These are the words that come first. God’s character is, above all, a character of love. And yet the passage does not stop there. God “will by no means clear the guilty.” He is holy and just. His love is not weak, and his justice is not harsh.

Theologians sometimes divide God’s attributes into two groups. Some are incommunicable, meaning that they belong to God alone: his self-existence, his infinity, his unchangeableness, his omnipresence, his omniscience, his omnipotence. Others are communicable, meaning that human beings, made in his image, can reflect them in a limited way: love, mercy, justice, holiness, wisdom, faithfulness. This division helps explain why the Bible calls us to be like God (Ephesians 5:1) and also reminds us that he is infinitely beyond us.

The two attributes in tension in Exodus 34 are love and justice, and the rest of the Bible is the story of how they meet. How can a God who forgives iniquity also refuse to clear the guilty? The answer is not given here. It is given at the cross, where, as Paul writes, God is "just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus" (Romans 3:26). The two halves of Exodus 34:7 are held together in Christ.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Look at the setting of each passage. The first comes at the beginning of God's work of redemption, when he sends Moses to bring Israel out of Egypt. The second comes after Israel has broken the covenant by worshiping the golden calf. In the first, God's name is an assurance that he will keep his promises. In the second, God's character is his answer to the question that Israel's sin raises: is it over?

God's response to a failed covenant is to describe himself. He does not explain a method or lay out terms. He says who he is. "The LORD, the LORD, a God merciful and gracious." The ground for hope after sin is not that people will do better but that God is who he is. This is what makes grace possible.

It matters, too, that Moses bows and worships. A right knowledge of God does not lead to pride but to worship. If you ever study the doctrine of God and find it making you proud or merely curious, something has gone wrong. The right response is Moses' response: to bow your head, and worship.

Finally, take note of the two kinds of statements in 34:7. They are not in contradiction. God is serious about sin because he is good. And he is willing to forgive because he is good. If he ignored sin, he would not be good. If he never forgave, he would not be merciful. The God of the Bible is both.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus claims the divine name in John 8:58 and says, "Whoever has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9). John 1:14 says that the Word "dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory…full of grace and truth," echoing "abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness." Paul writes that God put forward Christ "to show his righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins" (Romans 3:25).

STEP 6

Application

Try to describe God, in your own words, using the list in Exodus 34:6-7. Which attribute do you find easiest to believe? Which is harder?

If you find it hard to believe in God's mercy, read these verses again, and notice that he said them about himself after Israel's worst sin.

Pray the passage as a prayer: "LORD, you are merciful and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness." Let it become your first thought about God.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for who he is: self-existing, unchanging, merciful, and just.
- Thank him that in Jesus the name I AM is made known.
- Tell him which of his attributes you most need to remember today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

"God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you."

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 97 · WEEK 14

Psalm 106:1-23

Israel's history of unfaithfulness, grace despite rebellion

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 106:1-23. This is a confession psalm, a summary of Israel's early failures told from the standpoint of people who know that their own record is no better. Read it slowly and listen for the one line that keeps the history from being a list of defeats.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You have just begun the story of the exodus, and this psalm looks back on it from centuries later. It is one of the great historical psalms of the Bible, along with Psalms 78, 105, and 136. The author does not know the details of how it will all turn out, but he knows that Israel has a long history of failing God, and that God has a long history of being faithful. The psalm will return in two parts, and between them you will read the whole exodus story. Think of it as a preview.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm begins with praise: "Praise the LORD! Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever!" (v. 1).
2. A confession follows: "Both we and our fathers have sinned; we have committed iniquity; we have done wickedness" (v. 6).
3. At the Red Sea, the fathers "did not consider your wondrous works…but rebelled by the sea" (v. 7).
4. "Yet he saved them for his name's sake, that he might make known his mighty power" (v. 8).
5. "He rebuked the Red Sea, and it became dry" (v. 9). "Then they believed his words; they sang his praise" (v. 12).

6. “But they soon forgot his works; they did not wait for his counsel” (v. 13).
7. In the wilderness, they “craved to the full,” and God “gave them what they asked, but sent a wasting disease among them” (vv. 14-15).
8. The earth swallowed Dathan and Abiram, who challenged Moses’ authority (vv. 16-18).
9. “They made a calf in Horeb and worshiped a metal image. They exchanged the glory of God for the image of an ox that eats grass” (vv. 19-20).
10. “Therefore he said he would destroy them, had not Moses, his chosen one, stood in the breach before him, to turn away his wrath from destroying them” (v. 23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The structure of the psalm is a lesson in itself. It begins and ends with praise. In the middle, it tells a long story of failure. The psalm is not a bitter complaint about Israel. It is an act of worship that tells the truth about sin and the truth about God.

Notice the first confession in verse 6: “Both we and our fathers have sinned.” The psalmist does not blame his ancestors. He includes himself. This is the heart of honest confession. It is not enough to say that the past generation failed. We are part of the same story, with the same tendencies.

Then look at the pattern in the history. Israel sees a miracle and believes. A few days later, they forget. This is the thing the psalm keeps saying: “They soon forgot his works.” Forgetting is a form of sin, and it is the root of other sins. When you stop remembering what God has done, you stop trusting what he will do. This is why the Bible so often calls people to remember: to keep the Passover, to set up memorial stones, to tell the story to children.

The most shocking detail is verse 20: “They exchanged the glory of God for the image of an ox that eats grass.” It is meant to sound absurd. The people have seen the greatest display of God’s power in history, and they traded it for a statue of a grass-eating animal. Paul will pick up this phrase in Romans 1:23 to describe the human condition. We all do this, with money, success, comfort, and image.

But the line that carries the psalm is verse 8. “Yet he saved them for his name’s sake.” God’s rescue does not depend on Israel’s merit, since they did not have any. It rests on his own character and name. That is the foundation of grace.

The last verse in the section points to a mediator. “Moses, his chosen one, stood in the breach.” A breach is a gap in a wall, and a man standing in it takes the full force of the attack. God would have destroyed Israel, but Moses stepped between. It is a picture of what Christ will do on a much grander scale.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul uses the phrase of verse 20 in Romans 1:23, and in 1 Corinthians 10:1-13 he uses Israel's wilderness history as a warning and encouragement to the church. Hebrews 3:7-19 calls believers not to harden their hearts as Israel did. Ezekiel 22:30 describes God looking for someone to "stand in the breach" and finding no one. Jesus stands in that breach fully.

STEP 6

Application

Make a short list of what God has done for you in the past year. Put it somewhere you will see it. Forgetting is the first step toward drifting.

Confess honestly, as the psalmist does, using the word "we." Pray for your church and community, not only for yourself.

Ask yourself what you are tempted to exchange for the glory of God, and bring it to Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the lesser things you have exchanged for God's glory.
- Thank him for saving you for his name's sake.
- Thank him for the one who stands in the breach for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

"God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you."

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 98 · WEEK 14

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Exodus 3:14 slowly, several times, and then try to say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you."

EXODUS 3:14

REST

Meditation

Exodus 3:14 gives you a name to carry with you, and it is not an easy one. "I AM WHO I AM." It is the most compact statement about God in the Bible, and it has been a source of wonder for the people of God for three thousand years.

Begin with the simplicity of it. God does not say, "I am the powerful one," or "I am the king," or "I am the one who will save you." He says, "I AM." He is. He exists. He is the source of all that is, and he needs nothing. Before there was anything, there was God.

Notice who God says this to. It is not to philosophers or scholars. It is to a shepherd who is afraid, in the middle of a desert. The God who exists in himself, who does not depend on anything, has come to a nobody in a wilderness to say that he will rescue a nation of slaves. The greatest being in the universe is the one who sees the affliction of his people.

And notice the second half: “I AM has sent me to you.” The name is not just a statement about God’s nature. It is a promise to his people. He will be there. He will be what they need. “I will be with you,” he said to Moses in verse 12, and the name is the guarantee.

For the Christian, there is a final note. Jesus said, “Before Abraham was, I am” (John 8:58). The one who spoke from the bush became flesh and walked among us. Everything that is true of God’s name is true of Jesus.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the book of Exodus. You read how a new king arose who did not know Joseph, how Israel was enslaved, and how two midwives saved the Hebrew boys. You watched Moses be born, hidden in a basket, raised in Pharaoh’s house, and driven into the wilderness. You stood with him at the burning bush and heard God reveal his name. You saw him offer every excuse and God answer each with himself. On the doctrinal day, you studied the existence and attributes of God, from his self-existence in the name I AM to his character of mercy and justice in Exodus 34. In Psalm 106, you read a confession of Israel’s early failures and heard the line that holds it together: God saved them for his name’s sake. The week taught that God sees, hears, and remembers, and that he comes down to rescue.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses had a list of excuses, and God answered each one with a promise of his own presence. What is your list of excuses for something God has asked of you? Write them down, and next to each one write a promise from God.

How does Jesus’ statement, “Before Abraham was, I am,” change the way you read the burning bush? What does it mean to you that the God of Exodus 3 has come in the flesh?

Which part of the description in Exodus 34:6-7 do you find hardest to believe about God? Why? How would your life change if you believed it more fully?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he sees, hears, and knows.

Rest in who he is, and tell him what you are laying down this Sabbath.

Thank him for Jesus, in whom his name is fulfilled.

DAY 99 · WEEK 15

Exodus 5:1-7:25

Pharaoh hardens; Moses discouraged; the plagues begin

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 5:1-7:25. Moses and Aaron go to Pharaoh for the first time, and everything gets worse. Read it as the story of a man who obeys God and sees the result make his people's lives harder, and notice how God responds to Moses' discouragement.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You have just left Moses at the burning bush with a commission and a promise. Now he goes to Egypt and puts it to the test. The next several chapters tell the story of the ten plagues, which are the most dramatic series of events in the Old Testament. They are a contest between the LORD and the greatest empire on earth. But before the plagues begin, there is a long scene of disappointment. The first attempt to free Israel does not work. In the process, the question the whole book turns on is made clear: who is the LORD, and will Pharaoh obey him?

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses and Aaron say to Pharaoh, "Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel, Let my people go, that they may hold a feast to me in the wilderness" (5:1).
2. Pharaoh answers, "Who is the LORD, that I should obey his voice and let Israel go? I do not know the LORD, and moreover, I will not let Israel go" (5:2).
3. Pharaoh makes the labor harder by requiring bricks without straw (5:6-9).
4. The Israelite foremen blame Moses: "You have made us stink before Pharaoh" (5:21).
5. Moses complains to God: "O Lord, why have you done evil to this people? Why did you ever send me?" (5:22).

6. God answers, “Now you shall see what I will do to Pharaoh” (6:1), and he says again, “I am the LORD” (6:2, 6, 7, 8).
7. God makes a series of promises: “I will bring you out…I will deliver you…I will redeem you…I will take you to be my people, and I will be your God” (6:6-7).
8. But the people “did not listen to Moses, because of their broken spirit and harsh slavery” (6:9). Moses says he has “uncircumcised lips” (6:12).
9. God says, “I have made you like God to Pharaoh, and your brother Aaron shall be your prophet” (7:1). He says, “I will harden Pharaoh’s heart” (7:3).
10. Aaron’s staff becomes a serpent and swallows the magicians’ serpents (7:10-12). The Nile is turned to blood (7:14-25).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Pharaoh’s first question is the right one. “Who is the LORD?” He does not know, and he will find out. The whole sequence of plagues is the answer. God says over and over that the purpose is that Egypt and Israel will know that he is the LORD (7:5). It is a knowledge that comes through action.

The worsening of Israel’s conditions is a test of Moses’ faith, and it is a test for every believer. Often, when you try to obey God, things get harder before they get better. The people blame Moses. Moses blames God. This is one of the more honest scenes in the Bible. Moses does not hide what he feels. He says, “Why did you ever send me?” And God does not rebuke him. He answers with a restatement of who he is and what he will do.

God’s answer in chapter 6 is the heart of the passage. Listen to the four, or five, “I will” statements: bring out, deliver, redeem, take, and later in verse 8, bring in. This is a gospel in miniature. He will free them from the burden, rescue them from slavery, and redeem them with an outstretched arm. And then comes the covenant goal: “I will take you to be my people, and I will be your God.” The purpose of redemption is relationship. They are rescued in order to belong.

The people cannot hear it. Their spirit is broken. This is another honest detail. Some pain makes it hard to receive good news. God does not scold them for it. He continues to act.

The hardening of Pharaoh is a topic that deserves care. The text speaks of it in several ways. God says he will harden Pharaoh’s heart (4:21; 7:3). Pharaoh’s heart is also described as hardened without any stated agent (7:13), and later Pharaoh hardens his own heart (8:15, 32). The Bible holds these together: God is sovereign over Pharaoh’s will, and Pharaoh is responsible for his choices. Paul will take this up in Romans 9:17-18, saying that God raised

up Pharaoh to show his power. You may find this hard. It is worth sitting with the discomfort rather than explaining it away. The first thing to see is that God's purpose is to reveal who he is, and the second is that Pharaoh was not coerced into evil. He was an oppressor who did what he wanted.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus says to his disciples that "in the world you will have tribulation," and then, "take heart; I have overcome the world" (John 16:33). The four "I will" promises of 6:6-7 are echoed in Jesus' words in John 10:28 and in Titus 2:14, where he "gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession." Romans 9:14-24 takes up the question of Pharaoh's hardening.

STEP 6

Application

Are you discouraged because obeying God made things harder? Take Moses' complaint to God, as he did. He can bear it.

Memorize Exodus 6:6-7. Use the promises as your own. Notice that they are about God's action, not yours.

If someone in your life is too broken to hear good news, pray for them and keep showing them love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring your complaint about how hard things are to God, honestly.
- Ask him to remind you who he is.
- Ask for the courage to keep going.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

“The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you.”

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 100 · WEEK 15

Exodus 8:1-9:35

Plagues of frogs, gnats, flies, livestock, and boils

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 8:1-9:35. These chapters contain the plagues of frogs, gnats, flies, the death of livestock, boils, and hail. Do not rush. Look for the phrase “that you may know,” and watch what happens each time Pharaoh seems to give in.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The plagues are not random disasters. Each one is aimed at something the Egyptians trusted, such as the Nile, the frogs associated with the goddess Heqet, the animals associated with their religion, and the sky. God says that through the plagues he will execute “judgments” on all the gods of Egypt (Exodus 12:12). They are a contest between the LORD and the powers that seemed to rule Egypt. They are also a mercy, because they give Pharaoh repeated chances to let Israel go.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Moses says, “Let my people go, that they may serve me” (8:1). The plague of frogs fills the land, and Pharaoh asks Moses to pray to the LORD to remove it (8:8).
2. When the frogs die, Pharaoh “hardened his heart and would not listen to them” (8:15).
3. The magicians cannot produce gnats and say to Pharaoh, “This is the finger of God” (8:19).
4. With the flies, God says, “I will set apart the land of Goshen…that you may know that I am the LORD in the midst of the earth” (8:22).
5. The livestock of Egypt die, but not one of the animals of Israel (9:6).

6. The boils afflict the magicians themselves, so that they "could not stand before Moses" (9:11). "The LORD hardened the heart of Pharaoh" (9:12).
7. God says to Pharaoh, "For this purpose I have raised you up, to show you my power, so that my name may be proclaimed in all the earth" (9:16).
8. Before the hail, God offers a chance to shelter the servants and livestock. Some Egyptians who feared the word of the LORD brought them in (9:19-21).
9. Pharaoh says, "I have sinned this time; the LORD is in the right, and I and my people are in the wrong" (9:27), and then he sins again (9:34-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

There is a pattern in the plagues, and it is worth noticing. Pharaoh is confronted. He stalls, then gives way under pressure, and then goes back on his promise when the pressure is lifted. This is a picture of a heart that is not changed by judgment alone. Frogs, gnats, flies, and boils make him say what he must, but nothing in him changes. This is a warning to every one of us that pain alone does not make a person repent. You need a new heart.

The magicians are a surprising feature of the story. At first they copy Moses' signs. But with the gnats, they fail and confess, "This is the finger of God." Even Pharaoh's own advisers have to admit that something beyond them is at work. And by the sixth plague they cannot even stand. The power of the Egyptian gods is shown to be empty.

God makes a distinction between Egypt and Israel. In the land of Goshen there are no flies, and Israel's livestock do not die. The plagues are not simple natural disasters. They are directed, and God protects his own. This is the theme of redemption, to which the narrative keeps returning: God sets his people apart.

The most important statement in these chapters comes in 9:16. "For this purpose I have raised you up, to show you my power, so that my name may be proclaimed in all the earth." God's goal is bigger than freeing Israel. He wants all the world to know who he is. You can see that the exodus is always for the sake of his name, and that this is a good thing. The best thing that could happen to any person is to know the true God.

Then there is the hail. God gives a warning to those who will hear. Some Egyptians, "who feared the word of the LORD," gather their servants and flocks indoors. This is a small piece of mercy in the middle of judgment: even in Egypt, anyone who trusted God's word was spared. It is a hint of what the book will say later, that foreigners could join Israel (12:38).

Pharaoh's confession in 9:27 is the most striking detail. He says all the right words: "I have sinned. The LORD is in the right." But by verse 34 he is sinning again. A confession without repentance is just speech. Compare it to Psalm 106, where Israel also sang God's praise and soon forgot.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 16 describes the bowls of judgment in language drawn from these plagues. Romans 9:17 quotes Exodus 9:16. Jesus said that "everyone to whom much was given, of him much will be required" (Luke 12:48). Jesus also distinguishes true repentance from regret in the parable of the two sons (Matthew 21:28-32) and in Paul's words about "godly grief" in 2 Corinthians 7:10.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself if there is a pattern in your life of making promises to God under pressure and forgetting them afterward. Bring it to him honestly.

If you are tempted to think that God's judgments are arbitrary, notice how patient he is in these chapters. He gives repeated warnings and offers shelter.

Remember that God sets his people apart. Thank him for the ways he has marked you as his own.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for his patience with those who resist him, and for the mercy in his warnings.
- Ask him for a heart that truly repents, not just a mouth that says so.
- Thank him for setting his people apart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

“The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you.”

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 101 · WEEK 15

Exodus 10:1-11:10

Locusts, darkness, and the warning of the firstborn

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 10:1-11:10. These chapters contain the plagues of locusts and darkness, and the announcement of the last plague. Read them as the climax of the confrontation, and notice how Pharaoh's bargaining shows what his heart is really protecting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Seven plagues have passed. Egypt is ruined: the Nile is blood, the land is covered in frogs, flies, and dead animals, and its crops have been shattered by hail. Pharaoh's own officials say, "Do you not yet understand that Egypt is destroyed?" (10:7). Still he refuses. The last three plagues are the most terrible, and they lead up to the event that will define Israel's identity for the rest of its history.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Moses to go to Pharaoh, "that I may show these signs of mine among them, and that you may tell in the hearing of your son and of your grandson how I have dealt harshly with the Egyptians" (10:1-2).
2. Pharaoh's servants beg, "How long shall this man be a snare to us? Let the men go, that they may serve the LORD their God" (10:7).
3. Pharaoh bargains: only the men may go (10:11). The locusts eat everything that is left after the hail (10:12-15).
4. After the locusts, Pharaoh says, "I have sinned against the LORD your God, and against you" (10:16), and then hardens his heart again.
5. The ninth plague is "a darkness to be felt" that lasts three days, but "all the people of Israel had light where they lived" (10:21-23).

6. Pharaoh offers another bargain: the people may go, but their flocks and herds must stay. Moses answers, “Not a hoof shall be left behind” (10:24-26).
7. Pharaoh says, “Get away from me; take care never to see my face again” (10:28). Moses replies, “You have spoken rightly. I will not see your face again” (10:29).
8. God announces the last plague: “About midnight I will go out in the midst of Egypt, and every firstborn in the land of Egypt shall die” (11:4-5).
9. “Not a dog shall growl against any of the people of Israel…that you may know that the LORD makes a distinction between Egypt and Israel” (11:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Pharaoh’s bargains are worth studying, because people still bargain with God in the same ways. First he says, “Go and sacrifice here in the land.” That is, serve God, but on my terms and in my territory. Then he says, “Only the men may go.” That is, serve God, but leave your children and keep your families under my control. Then, “Go, but leave your flocks.” That is, serve God, but keep what you own under my power. Each time Moses refuses. “Not a hoof shall be left behind.” Everything belongs to God, and nothing can be held back.

The pattern is not about distant history. Many people want a version of faith that costs them nothing: Christianity at church but not at home, in the heart but not in the wallet, for the individual but not for the family. Moses’ answer is that God asks for the whole thing.

The plague of darkness is the strangest. It is described as a “darkness to be felt.” It was so thick that people did not see one another or rise from their places for three days. This is a reversal of the first day of creation, when God said, “Let there be light.” The land of Egypt is un-created. It is also a picture of what it means to live without God: a darkness that you can feel. And in Goshen, the people of God had light. That is a vivid image of the difference God makes.

Pharaoh’s final words to Moses are chilling. “Take care never to see my face again.” He sends away the one who has brought him warnings and a way out. The man who says no to God’s messenger has sealed his own fate. Moses’ answer, “You have spoken rightly,” is calm. The time for negotiation is over.

The last plague is announced in 11:4-8, and the tone is grave. Moses speaks “in hot anger” (11:8), but the message is clear and sorrowful: there will be a great cry throughout Egypt such as never was before. God is not delighting in this. It is a judgment on a nation that has killed Israel’s sons (Exodus 1:22) and refused to repent. And in the middle of the announcement is a promise: “The LORD makes a distinction between Egypt and Israel.” You will see tomorrow how.

STEP 5

Connection

The darkness of the ninth plague has parallels in the darkness at the cross (Matthew 27:45), when Jesus, the light of the world, bore God's judgment. Paul writes in Colossians 1:13 that God "has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son." John 1:5 says, "The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has not overcome it." Luke 14:33 says, "Any one of you who does not renounce all that he has cannot be my disciple."

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself where you are bargaining with God. Which parts of your life are you trying to keep out of his reach? It may be your time, your money, your family, or a relationship. Bring that area to him this week.

Thank God that you have light. If you know someone who is in darkness, pray for them, and look for a chance to speak of Christ.

Pray for those who do not know God and who are hardening themselves against him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have bargained with God or held something back.
- Ask him to take your whole self, your family, and your possessions.
- Thank him for bringing you out of darkness into his light.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

"The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you."

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 102 · WEEK 15

Exodus 12:1-13:16

The Passover instituted, the lamb and the blood

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 67 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 12:1-13:16. This is the central chapter of the Old Testament's story of redemption. Read it slowly and with great care. Mark each instruction about the lamb, and notice what saves the people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Everything in the book of Exodus has been leading to this night. God is about to strike Egypt with the last plague, and he gives Israel a way to be protected: the Passover. It is the foundational event of Israel's national life, and the Jewish people have kept the feast ever since. For Christians, it is the great shadow of the cross. Jesus died at Passover time, and he is called "our Passover lamb" (1 Corinthians 5:7). Understanding the Passover is the key to understanding what Jesus did.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This month shall be for you the beginning of months. It shall be the first month of the year for you" (12:2).
2. Each household is to take a lamb "without blemish, a male a year old" (12:5).
3. The lamb is kept until the fourteenth day, and then "the whole assembly of the congregation of Israel shall kill their lambs at twilight" (12:6).
4. They are to take some of the blood "and put it on the two doorposts and the lintel of the houses" (12:7).
5. They are to eat the meat roasted, with unleavened bread and bitter herbs, "with your belt fastened, your sandals on your feet, and your staff in your hand" (12:8-11).

6. “It is the LORD’s Passover” (12:11).
7. God says, “The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you” (12:13).
8. The feast of unleavened bread is to be kept as a memorial, and children are to be taught what it means (12:14-20, 26-27).
9. At midnight, the LORD struck down all the firstborn in Egypt, and “there was a great cry in Egypt, for there was not a house where someone was not dead” (12:29-30).
10. Pharaoh calls for Moses and says, “Up, go out from among my people” (12:31). A “mixed multitude” goes up with Israel (12:38).
11. God commands that every firstborn male be consecrated to him, and that every firstborn son be redeemed (13:1-2, 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Passover is a story about substitution. In every house in Egypt, the firstborn was under a sentence of death. The difference between Israel and Egypt was not that Israel was more righteous. The difference was that, in Israel’s homes, a lamb had died in place of the firstborn son. The blood on the doorpost was the sign that the death had already occurred. When God saw it, he passed over.

Look at the details. The lamb is “without blemish.” It is chosen on the tenth day and kept in the house for four days, long enough for the family to become attached to it. It is killed by the whole community. Its blood is applied to the door. The meat is eaten. Every part of the ritual teaches something. The lamb is innocent. The death is public. The blood is a visible sign. And the family has to take it in.

Notice how little the people do. They do not fight, or earn their freedom. They do not even go out of the house. They shelter under the blood. This is why the New Testament uses the Passover to teach grace. We are saved not by what we do but by the blood of the Lamb applied to us.

The tone of the ritual is also important. They are to eat in haste, ready to leave. It is a night of judgment and of rescue. Salvation is not a calm event. But it is secure.

The Passover is also designed to be remembered. Three times in these chapters God tells the people to teach their children: “What do you mean by this service?” (12:26). The parents are to say, “It is the sacrifice of the LORD’s Passover, for he passed over the houses of the people of Israel in Egypt” (12:27). Redemption has to be told, again and again, to every generation.

Chapter 13 adds a second teaching: the firstborn belongs to God. Every firstborn son had to be redeemed, bought back, with the sacrifice of a lamb (13:13). A father would answer his son's question by saying, "By a strong hand the LORD brought us out of Egypt" (13:14). Redemption creates ownership. Those who have been bought belong to the one who bought them.

STEP 5

Connection

John the Baptist said of Jesus, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29). Jesus was crucified at Passover time, and John notes that "not one of his bones will be broken" (John 19:36, quoting Exodus 12:46). At the Last Supper, he took the Passover meal and gave it new meaning (Luke 22:14-20). Peter says we were ransomed "with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot" (1 Peter 1:18-19). Hebrews 11:28 says Moses kept the Passover "by faith."

STEP 6

Application

When you take the Lord's Supper, think of the Passover. You are not earning anything. You are receiving the benefits of a Lamb who died in your place.

Ask yourself if you are relying on the blood of Christ or on your own record. Say aloud, "When he sees the blood, he will pass over me."

Think about how you can tell the story of your redemption to a child or a friend this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the blood of the Lamb, and say in your own words what it means that he passes over you.
- Ask him to help you tell the story to someone younger.
- Tell him you trust Christ and not yourself.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

“The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you.”

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 103 · WEEK 15

Exodus 13:17-14:31

The Red Sea crossing, redemption through water

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 13:17-14:31. This is the crossing of the Red Sea, the climax of the exodus. Read the story as a drama in three parts: Israel's fear, God's promise through Moses, and the crossing itself.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel has left Egypt, with the bones of Joseph carried along as a sign of the promise (13:19). But the journey is not easy. God leads them by a longer route, and then into what looks like a trap, with the sea in front and Pharaoh's army behind. It is a test of whether they will trust the God who has just rescued them. Everything that follows in Israel's history, in the Psalms, and in the New Testament, looks back to this moment.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God did not lead them by the road through the land of the Philistines, "for God said, Lest the people change their minds when they see war and return to Egypt" (13:17).
2. "The LORD went before them by day in a pillar of cloud to lead them along the way, and by night in a pillar of fire to give them light" (13:21).
3. God tells Moses to camp by the sea, so that Pharaoh will think they are wandering confused. "And I will get glory over Pharaoh and all his host" (14:4).
4. Pharaoh changes his mind and pursues with six hundred chariots (14:5-9).
5. The people cry out in fear and say to Moses, "Is it because there were no graves in Egypt that you have taken us away to die in the wilderness?" (14:11).

6. Moses answers, “Fear not, stand firm, and see the salvation of the LORD, which he will work for you today...The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent” (14:13-14).
7. The angel of God and the pillar of cloud move between Israel and the Egyptians, bringing darkness to one side and light to the other (14:19-20).
8. Moses stretches out his hand, a strong east wind drives the sea back, and “the people of Israel went into the midst of the sea on dry ground, the waters being a wall to them on their right hand and on their left” (14:21-22).
9. The waters return and cover the Egyptians. “Not one of them remained” (14:28).
10. “Thus the LORD saved Israel that day from the hand of the Egyptians...And the people feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in his servant Moses” (14:30-31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to see is that God led them into the trap on purpose. This is not a case of bad navigation. God said, “I will get glory over Pharaoh.” The danger was real, and the people were right to be afraid. But the danger was part of God’s plan to show his power. This is a theme throughout Scripture: God sometimes brings his people to the end of their own resources so that his salvation will be clearly his.

Moses’ answer is the center of the passage, and one of the great statements of faith in the Bible. “Fear not, stand firm, and see the salvation of the LORD.” There are three commands: do not be afraid, stand still, and watch. This is not a call to passivity in everything, but in this moment there was nothing Israel could do. They were not going to fight their way out. The next line is the promise: “The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent.” The deliverance would be entirely God’s work.

Then notice how God works. He did not remove the sea. He divided it. Israel walked through on dry ground with water on each side. The very thing that seemed to be their death, the sea, became their path. And the same sea became the Egyptians’ grave. The same event is salvation for one people and judgment for another.

The last verses tell you what the miracle accomplished in the hearts of the people. They “feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in his servant Moses.” Redemption produced faith. We saw in Psalm 106 that the faith did not last, but at that moment it was real.

For the New Testament writers, the crossing of the sea is a picture of baptism. Paul says that "all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea" (1 Corinthians 10:2). Passing through the water means leaving the old master behind and belonging to a new leader. It also looks to the cross, where Christ, the greater Moses, passes through the waters of judgment so that his people can walk through on dry ground.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 43:2 says, "When you pass through the waters, I will be with you." Paul compares the crossing to baptism in 1 Corinthians 10:1-2. Peter says that "baptism…now saves you" as an appeal to God for a good conscience (1 Peter 3:21), after speaking of the flood. Revelation 15:3 describes the saints singing "the song of Moses, the servant of God."

STEP 6

Application

Think of a place where you feel hemmed in, with the sea in front and an enemy behind. Say aloud, "The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent."

Take a few minutes of true silence in prayer this week. Resist the urge to fix the situation, and watch for God's salvation.

Remember your baptism, if you have been baptized. If you have not, ask what it would mean to take that step.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you fear when you face a sea you cannot cross.
- Ask him to fight for you and to teach you to be still.
- Thank him for the salvation he worked in Christ.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

“The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you.”

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 104 · WEEK 15

Psalm 106:24-48

Israel's rebellion in the wilderness; God's mercy endures

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 106:24-48. This is the second half of the confession psalm you began on Day 97. Read it as a story that moves from rebellion to rescue, and look for the verses that describe what God does when his people forget him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On Day 97, you read the first half of this psalm, which described Israel's failures at the Red Sea and at Horeb. Today you read the rest, which takes you through the wilderness, the entrance to the land, and the long years in Canaan. Because you have just read the crossing of the sea and the Passover, this psalm shows you what happens to a redeemed people who do not stay close to their Redeemer. It is a sober picture, and it ends with a plea.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Then they despised the pleasant land, having no faith in his promise" (v. 24). They "murmured in their tents" (v. 25).
2. God swore that he would cast them down in the wilderness (v. 26).
3. They yoked themselves to the Baal of Peor and ate sacrifices offered to the dead (v. 28).
4. Phinehas stood up and intervened, "and that was counted to him as righteousness from generation to generation forever" (vv. 30-31).
5. At the waters of Meribah, "it went ill with Moses on their account, for they made his spirit bitter, and he spoke rashly with his lips" (vv. 32-33).
6. They did not destroy the peoples as the LORD commanded, but "mingled with the nations and learned to do as they did" (vv. 34-35).

7. They sacrificed their sons and daughters to the demons (v. 37).
8. The LORD "was angry with his people, and he abhorred his heritage" (v. 40), and gave them into the hand of the nations.
9. "Nevertheless, he looked upon their distress, when he heard their cry. For their sake he remembered his covenant, and relented according to the abundance of his steadfast love" (vv. 44-45).
10. "Save us, O LORD our God, and gather us from among the nations, that we may give thanks to your holy name and glory in your praise" (v. 47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of this psalm is harder than the first. It spans many generations, and the failure is repeated. Each generation seems to start again. The sins are the same: unbelief, idolatry, and compromise. They do not trust God's promise of the land. They give themselves to other gods. They stop short of obedience and imitate the nations around them.

One phrase stands out: "They made his spirit bitter, and he spoke rashly with his lips." Even Moses, the faithful servant, is brought down by the people's sin. At Meribah, he struck the rock in anger, and because of it, was not allowed into the land (Numbers 20:1-13). This is a sad reminder that no human leader is perfect. Even the best of them fails. You need a greater Moses.

The story of Phinehas is one of those rare bright spots. His zeal turned away God's anger, and the psalm says that it was "counted to him as righteousness." The same phrase is used of Abraham in Genesis 15:6, and Paul uses it for the believer in Romans 4. The psalm presents righteousness as something credited. It is a theme that will return throughout the Bible.

The darkest verse is verse 37: they sacrificed their sons and daughters to demons. The people who had been rescued from Egypt, where Pharaoh murdered baby boys, now did the same thing to their own children. This shows how deep sin goes. Rescue from slavery does not remove the heart's tendency to evil.

And yet the psalm does not end in despair. In verse 44, "Nevertheless." It is one of the great words in the Bible. "He looked upon their distress, when he heard their cry. For their sake he remembered his covenant." This is exactly what you read in Exodus 2:24. God hears, and remembers, and relents. The foundation is "the abundance of his steadfast love." The psalm ends with a prayer for a future rescue: "Save us, O LORD our God." This is the prayer that Israel will pray in exile, and the prayer that the church prays as we wait for the final salvation.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that “these things happened to them as an example, but they were written down for our instruction” (1 Corinthians 10:11). Hebrews 3 and 4 call believers not to fall as Israel did. Romans 4:3-5 quotes Genesis 15:6 on righteousness being credited. Jesus is the greater Moses, who is faithful over God’s house as a Son (Hebrews 3:5-6). The “Nevertheless” of verse 44 finds its fullest expression in Ephesians 2:4: “But God, being rich in mercy.”

STEP 6

Application

Be honest about where you tend to compromise. Is there a pattern of imitating the world around you? Bring it to God and ask for help.

Read Psalm 106:44-45 as a promise to yourself in your weakness. Write the word “Nevertheless” on a card.

Pray the last verse for the church, asking God to gather his scattered and discouraged people.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the ways you see yourself in Israel’s drifting.
- Thank God for hearing and remembering his covenant.
- Ask him to gather his people and make them glad.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 15

“The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you.”

EXODUS 12:13

DAY 105 · WEEK 15

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Exodus 12:13 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone you trust.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you."

EXODUS 12:13

REST

Meditation

Exodus 12:13 is the gospel in one sentence. It was spoken on the night before the exodus, and it says everything about how God saves.

"The blood shall be a sign for you." The blood was a sign for the people inside the house, not for God. It was the thing that gave them confidence that the judgment would not touch them. They did not have to feel safe. They had a sign. When you are afraid, the promise is not that you will feel better, but that there is a sign: the blood.

"When I see the blood." It is God who sees the blood, and the sight of it is what determines what he does. Notice what is not said. God does not say, "When I see your goodness" or "When I see your repentance." He says, "When I see the blood." The ground of your safety is not what is in you but what is on the door. A lamb has died in your place.

“I will pass over you.” This is the great promise. Judgment is real, and it falls on Egypt. But those under the blood are safe. The word “pass over” is related to a Hebrew verb that means to hover protectively, like a bird over its nest (Isaiah 31:5). God does not just skip the house. He guards it.

“And no plague will befall you to destroy you.” The protection is complete.

For the Christian, the blood is the blood of Christ. “Since, therefore, we have now been justified by his blood, much more shall we be saved by him from the wrath of God” (Romans 5:9). There is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:1). Every time you doubt whether you are safe, return to this verse.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the story of the plagues and the exodus. You watched Moses go to Pharaoh and make things worse, and you heard God answer his complaint with the promise to bring out, deliver, redeem, and take. You read the plagues of frogs, gnats, flies, livestock, boils, and hail, and saw how Pharaoh gave way and hardened his heart again and again. You watched Pharaoh bargain, and Moses refuse to leave a hoof behind. You read the instructions for the Passover and heard God say, “When I see the blood, I will pass over you.” Then you walked through the Red Sea on dry ground and saw the waters close over Pharaoh’s army. In Psalm 106, you read a confession of Israel’s later unfaithfulness, and the one word that rescues the story: “Nevertheless.” The week taught that salvation is God’s work, secured by the blood of a substitute.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Pharaoh bargained with God, offering part but not all. What part of your life do you tend to hold back from God? What would it look like to say, “Not a hoof shall be left behind”?

How does the Passover lamb help you understand what Jesus did on the cross? Think about the details: without blemish, its blood applied, protection from judgment. What does it mean for you personally that Christ is your Passover lamb?

Moses told Israel at the sea, “The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent.” What battle are you trying to fight on your own? What would it look like to be silent and let God fight?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that when he sees the blood, he passes over you.

Ask him to fight for you, and rest in him.

Tell him what you are tempted to trust apart from Christ.

DAY 106 · WEEK 16

Exodus 15:1-27

The song of Moses, redemption celebrated in worship

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 27 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 15:1-27. This is the first song in the Bible sung by the whole people of God. Read the first half aloud as a song of praise, and then read the second half as the first test after the song. Notice how quickly the singing is followed by complaining.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Red Sea is behind them, and the Egyptians are dead on the shore. For the first time in four hundred years, Israel is free. What does a free people do? They sing. Exodus 15 is the oldest extended poem in the Bible, and it is the model for the way that redemption is celebrated in worship. Moses and the people sing it, and Miriam leads the women in another song. It looks back at what God has done, and forward to what he will do. After the song comes the wilderness, and the first lesson in how fragile their praise can be.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will sing to the LORD, for he has triumphed gloriously; the horse and his rider he has thrown into the sea" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him" (v. 2).
3. "The LORD is a man of war; the LORD is his name" (v. 3).
4. "Who is like you, O LORD, among the gods? Who is like you, majestic in holiness, awesome in glorious deeds, doing wonders?" (v. 11).
5. "You have led in your steadfast love the people whom you have redeemed; you have guided them by your strength to your holy abode" (v. 13).

6. The nations will tremble (vv. 14-16), and God will plant his people "on your own mountain, the place, O LORD, which you have made for your abode" (v. 17).
7. "The LORD will reign forever and ever" (v. 18).
8. Miriam the prophetess takes a tambourine, and the women follow her with dancing, singing, "Sing to the LORD, for he has triumphed gloriously" (vv. 20-21).
9. After three days in the wilderness without water, they come to Marah, where the water is bitter, and the people grumble (vv. 22-24).
10. The LORD shows Moses a tree, which makes the water sweet. He tells Israel, "I am the LORD, your healer" (vv. 25-26). At Elim they find twelve springs and seventy palm trees (v. 27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The song is organized in three movements. The first (vv. 1-5) is a retelling of the victory at the sea. The second (vv. 6-12) praises God's power and holiness. The third (vv. 13-18) looks forward to the journey to the land and God's eternal reign. It is a poem of memory and hope.

The central line is in verse 2: "The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation." This verse will be quoted by Isaiah (12:2) and the Psalms (118:14). The word for "salvation" is yeshuah, the root of the name Jesus. The song is already pointing toward a greater salvation. Note too that the song is personal. "My strength…my God." The people have moved from asking Moses what he has done to them, to saying, "This is my God."

Verse 11 asks a rhetorical question that has an obvious answer: "Who is like you, O LORD, among the gods?" No one. The exodus is the demonstration that the God of Israel is not just a tribal deity but the Lord of the whole world. And he is "majestic in holiness." The song does not separate his power from his holiness. The God who defeats Pharaoh is the God whose character is pure.

The third movement is the one that people sometimes overlook. The song looks ahead: "You have led in your steadfast love the people whom you have redeemed." The tense is past, but the sentence is about the future, because the poet is so certain that God will finish what he has started that he speaks as though it is done. "You will bring them in and plant them." God's purpose is a place where he dwells with his people. The final line is a confession that carries the whole Bible forward: "The LORD will reign forever and ever."

Then comes the cold shower. In three days, the people are grumbling. The song has hardly died away. Marah, the bitter water, is the first test, and the people fail. God does not rebuke them but provides the tree. It is a lesson that he is the one who heals. The promise of verse 26

sets up the whole covenant: if they will listen to the LORD, they will not suffer as Egypt did. God's grace comes first, and then his commands.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 15:3 describes the redeemed standing by the sea of glass "and singing the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb." Isaiah 12:2 quotes verse 2. Paul sings the theme in Ephesians 5:19: "singing and making melody to the Lord with your heart." The tree that made the water sweet has been compared by many to the cross, which turns the bitterness of death into life.

STEP 6

Application

Sing this week. Even if you do not consider yourself a singer, find a hymn or song about what God has done for you, and sing it aloud.

Look at your own wilderness. Where is there a Marah, a place of bitterness? Ask God to show you the tree.

Notice the speed with which gratitude fades. Write down three things God has done for you recently, and thank him for them before the end of the day.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Sing or speak to God of what he has done for you, in your own words.

Ask him to heal what is bitter in your life.

Confess how quickly you forget, and ask him to teach you to sing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 107 · WEEK 16

Psalm 77

I cry aloud to God; I remember your wonders of old

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 77. It begins in distress and ends with a picture of the exodus. Read it aloud, and notice the exact moment when the psalmist turns from his own trouble to God's past deeds.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 77 was written by Asaph, who also wrote Psalm 73. Like that one, it is the prayer of a person whose faith is shaken. But where Psalm 73 turned on the sanctuary, this psalm turns on memory. The psalmist faces a time of such trouble that he cannot sleep. And then he remembers the exodus, which you have just read. The psalm shows how the story of redemption is meant to be used: as a resource for hard days.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I cry aloud to God, aloud to God, and he will hear me" (v. 1).
2. "In the day of my trouble I seek the Lord; in the night my hand is stretched out without wearying; my soul refuses to be comforted" (v. 2).
3. "When I remember God, I am distressed; when I meditate, my spirit faints" (v. 3).
4. "You hold my eyelids open; I am so troubled that I cannot speak" (v. 4).
5. He asks a series of questions: "Will the Lord spurn forever…? Has his steadfast love forever ceased? Has God forgotten to be gracious?" (vv. 7-9).
6. Then, "I will appeal to this, to the years of the right hand of the Most High" (v. 10).
7. "I will remember the deeds of the LORD; yes, I will remember your wonders of old" (v. 11).

8. “Your way, O God, is holy. What god is great like our God? You are the God who works wonders” (vv. 13-14).
9. “With your arm you redeemed your people, the children of Jacob and Joseph” (v. 15).
10. “Your way was through the sea, your path through the great waters; yet your footprints were unseen” (v. 19). “You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first nine verses of this psalm are a portrait of spiritual distress, and it is worth noticing what is unusual about it. “When I remember God, I am distressed.” You might expect that remembering God would be comforting. Here it is painful, because the psalmist remembers what God has been, and compares it to what he feels now. It is the distress of someone who believes in a good God and cannot reconcile that with his experience.

The questions of verses 7 to 9 are the real question at the heart of the psalm. Will the Lord reject forever? Has his steadfast love ceased? Has he forgotten? Each question is a way of asking whether the covenant is still good. And the psalmist does not answer them right away.

The turn comes in verse 10. “Then I said, I will appeal to this.” The Hebrew of this verse is difficult, and translations vary, but the sense is that the psalmist makes a decision. He will stop focusing on his feelings, and he will recall what God has done. “I will remember the deeds of the LORD.” This is a deliberate act of the will. He does not wait to feel like remembering.

What does he remember? The exodus. Verses 16 to 20 are a lyrical retelling of the crossing of the sea. The waters trembled. The depths shook. The clouds poured out water. God’s arrows and thunder flashed. The picture is of a storm, and God is at the center of it. And then the line that is the most striking of all: “Your way was through the sea…yet your footprints were unseen.” God’s way was through the sea, but you could not see his tracks. This is a profound description of providence. God was at work, with absolute power, but invisibly. There were no footprints.

That is the answer to the psalmist’s problem. His circumstances do not show God’s footprints, but that does not mean that God is not at work. The exodus proved that God can lead his people through impossible places without leaving a visible trace. And the psalm ends with the quiet image of a shepherd: “You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron.” He leads through human hands, and he leads like a shepherd.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul writes in Romans 11:33 about God's "paths beyond tracing out." Jesus asked his disciples to remember the feeding of the five thousand when they worried about bread (Mark 8:17-21). At the Lord's Supper, Jesus told his followers, "Do this in remembrance of me" (Luke 22:19). Psalm 77's pattern, of distress, then deliberate remembering, then worship, is also the pattern in Psalm 42 and Lamentations 3.

STEP 6

Application

When your feelings are overwhelming, remember on purpose. Write out a list of the deeds of the LORD in your life, and in the Bible. Read it aloud.

Think about a time you could not see God's footprints, and later saw that he had been working. Tell someone about it.

Take the Lord's Supper as an act of remembering, not only as a ritual.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry out to God, and tell him where your soul refuses to be comforted.
- Remember aloud a deed of God that you can hold on to.
- Thank him that he leads you even when you cannot see his footprints.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 108 · WEEK 16

Psalm 114

When Israel went out of Egypt, the sea fled

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 114. It has only eight verses, and it is one of the most compressed poems in the Psalter. Read it twice, once as a celebration of the exodus and once as a call to tremble before God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the third psalm in a row that looks back at the exodus. Psalm 106 was a confession, Psalm 77 was a memory in distress, and Psalm 114 is a burst of joy. It is part of the "Egyptian Hallel," Psalms 113 to 118, which Jewish families have sung at the Passover meal for centuries. It was probably among the songs that Jesus and his disciples sang after the Last Supper (Mark 14:26). In just a few lines, it tells the whole story of redemption through the language of nature responding to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When Israel went out from Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people of strange language" (v. 1).
2. "Judah became his sanctuary, Israel his dominion" (v. 2).
3. "The sea looked and fled; Jordan turned back" (v. 3).
4. "The mountains skipped like rams, the hills like lambs" (v. 4).
5. The psalmist asks the sea, the Jordan, and the mountains what is wrong with them (vv. 5-6).
6. "Tremble, O earth, at the presence of the Lord, at the presence of the God of Jacob" (v. 7).

7. “Who turns the rock into a pool of water, the flint into a spring of water” (v. 8).
8. The psalm has two halves: verses 1 to 4 describe what happened, and verses 5 to 8 call the earth to respond.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm does something unusual. It tells the story of the exodus without ever naming God until verse 7. The whole description is of Israel and the world’s reaction. The sea flees. The river turns back. The mountains leap. The poet leaves God offstage in order to make you feel his presence, like seeing the effect of a hurricane without the storm.

Verse 2 contains the heart of the exodus: “Judah became his sanctuary, Israel his dominion.” God did not just free Israel. He claimed them. They were redeemed to be his dwelling place and his kingdom. This is the purpose of the exodus: not just freedom from but freedom for. It is the same as the promise in Exodus 6:7: “I will take you to be my people, and I will be your God.”

The questions of verses 5 and 6 are a bit of poetic humor. The poet asks the sea, “What is wrong with you?” The answer is not stated, but it is obvious: the Lord is here. Creation is not a neutral stage. It is a servant of God, and when he moves, it responds. The sea and the river, which seemed so powerful to ancient people, flee at his command.

The last verse is the most wonderful. After the earth trembles, the God who made it “turns the rock into a pool of water.” He is not only the one who shakes mountains. He is also the one who turns hard stone into fresh water for thirsty people. The God of power is also the God of provision, and you will see this very story in tomorrow’s reading at Massah and Meribah. The same hand does both.

The progression of the psalm is worth noticing. It begins with a historic event. It moves to the response of nature. And it ends with a command to the whole earth to tremble before the presence of the Lord. This is what the exodus is meant to do. It is not just a story about the past. It is a call to every creature to recognize who God is.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul writes that Christ is “the rock” that followed Israel (1 Corinthians 10:4). Jesus said that he is the source of “living water” (John 4:14; 7:37-38). At Jesus’ death, the earth shook and the rocks were split (Matthew 27:51), and creation responded again to its Lord. Isaiah 44:3 and 48:21 also describe God providing water from the rock.

STEP 6

Application

Spend a few minutes outside this week, and notice the creation around you as a servant of God. Thank him for the rain, the rivers, and the hills.

Ask yourself if you tremble before the Lord, or if you have grown casual. Ask him to restore a healthy sense of awe.

Thank Jesus for being the rock from which living water flows.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tremble and rejoice before God, as the earth does.
- Thank him for Jesus, who gives living water.
- Tell him what you want to bring out of "Egypt" in your own life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 109 · WEEK 16

Exodus 16:1-18:27

Manna, quail, water from the rock, God provides

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 16:1-18:27. These chapters take Israel from the Red Sea toward Sinai. Read them as three tests: hunger in chapter 16, thirst and war in chapter 17, and leadership in chapter 18. Watch for the way God provides each time.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Israel is now six weeks out of Egypt, and the food they carried is gone. The wilderness is not a good place to feed millions of people. The next three chapters show what the first stages of life with God are like, and they are not easy. The people grumble. God answers with generosity. This is a school of dependence, and the lesson is that the God who redeemed them is the God who will provide for them every day.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people complain: “Would that we had died by the hand of the LORD in the land of Egypt, when we sat by the meat pots and ate bread to the full” (16:3).
2. God says, “Behold, I am about to rain bread from heaven for you” (16:4), and it is to test whether they will walk in his law.
3. In the morning, there is a fine, flake-like thing on the ground. They say, “What is it?” and Moses answers, “It is the bread that the LORD has given you to eat” (16:14-15). They call it manna.
4. Each person gathers as much as they need, “and whoever gathered much had nothing left over, and whoever gathered little had no lack” (16:18).
5. Those who keep it overnight find it full of worms and foul, except on the sixth day, when a double portion is given for the Sabbath (16:19-26).

6. At Massah and Meribah, the people quarrel with Moses for water. They ask, "Is the LORD among us or not?" (17:7).
7. God tells Moses to strike the rock at Horeb, and water comes out (17:5-6).
8. Amalek attacks. Joshua fights, and as long as Moses holds up his hands, Israel prevails, with Aaron and Hur holding them up (17:8-13).
9. Moses builds an altar and calls it "The LORD Is My Banner" (17:15).
10. Moses' father-in-law, Jethro, visits, and says, "Now I know that the LORD is greater than all gods" (18:11). He advises Moses to appoint judges to share the work (18:13-27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to see is how quickly the people go from song to complaint. It has been less than two months since they sang at the Red Sea. Now they say they wish they had died in Egypt. It is a ridiculous and also very human response. When life is hard, we tend to remember the past through rose-colored glasses. They forget the slavery and remember the meat pots.

God's response is gracious. He does not strike them down. He gives them bread from heaven. But he adds an important detail: it is a test. "That I may test them, whether they will walk in my law or not." The test is about daily dependence. They are to gather only what they need for the day. If they try to store it up, it spoils. The only exception is the sixth day, when they receive a double portion. This teaches them two lessons at once: trust God for tomorrow, and rest on the Sabbath. It also shows the connection between provision and rest, a link between the gift of food and the gift of the Sabbath that anticipates the commandments to come.

Moses later explains the purpose: "Man does not live by bread alone, but man lives by every word that comes from the mouth of the LORD" (Deuteronomy 8:3). The manna was a daily reminder that life comes from God's mouth.

At Massah and Meribah, the question is sharper: "Is the LORD among us or not?" It is the question that haunts the whole wilderness, and God answers it by giving water from the rock. The rock is struck once, and life flows from it.

The battle with Amalek is the first attack on Israel after the exodus, and the posture of Moses is the point. He stands with his hands raised, and when they fall, Israel loses. He needs help. Aaron and Hur support him. It is a picture of intercession, and the picture of a community that holds up its leaders. The victory is the LORD's, not Joshua's. That is why Moses names the altar, "The LORD is my banner."

Jethro's advice shows that God also works through ordinary wisdom. Moses is wearing himself out, and a foreign priest points out that the work must be shared. It is a reminder that good leadership means delegation and that humility is willing to receive counsel.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus says, "I am the bread of life" (John 6:35), and he contrasts himself with the manna: "Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died. This is the bread that comes down from heaven, so that one may eat of it and not die" (John 6:49-50). Paul says the rock was Christ (1 Corinthians 10:4). Jesus teaches us to pray, "Give us this day our daily bread" (Matthew 6:11). Hebrews 7:25 says Christ "always lives to make intercession" for his people.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for daily bread, and practice depending on God for each day. Resist the urge to store up anxiety about the future.

When you find yourself asking, "Is the LORD among us or not?", answer with what you know of him.

Ask who is holding up your hands, and whose hands you could hold up. Make a plan to encourage a pastor or a leader this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God for your daily bread, and tell him what worries you about tomorrow.
- Thank him for Jesus, the bread of life.
- Ask him to teach you to depend on him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 110 · WEEK 16

Exodus 19:1-20:26

Sinai; the Ten Commandments, law after redemption

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 19:1-20:26. This is Mount Sinai, the giving of the Ten Commandments. Pay close attention to the order: first God describes what he has done, then he describes who they are, and only then does he give the commandments.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Three months after leaving Egypt, Israel arrives at Mount Sinai. It is the turning point of the whole book. Everything before this point was rescue. Everything after is covenant, the formal relationship between God and Israel. The next several chapters are among the most important in the Old Testament, because they set out the terms of the Mosaic covenant. At the center is the Decalogue, the Ten Commandments. This is the day to remember that God redeems before he commands.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God says through Moses, “You yourselves have seen what I did to the Egyptians, and how I bore you on eagles” wings and brought you to myself’ (19:4).
2. “Now therefore, if you will indeed obey my voice and keep my covenant, you shall be my treasured possession among all peoples, for all the earth is mine” (19:5).
3. “And you shall be to me a kingdom of priests and a holy nation” (19:6).
4. The people answer together, “All that the LORD has spoken we will do” (19:8).
5. The people are consecrated, and boundaries are set around the mountain (19:10-13).
6. On the third day, there is thunder and lightning, a thick cloud, and a loud trumpet blast. “Mount Sinai was wrapped in smoke because the LORD had descended on it in fire”

(19:16-18).

7. God speaks: "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery" (20:2).
8. The commandments: no other gods; no carved images; do not take the LORD's name in vain; remember the Sabbath; honor your father and mother; do not murder, commit adultery, steal, bear false witness, or covet (20:3-17).
9. The people tremble and say to Moses, "You speak to us, and we will hear; but do not let God speak to us, lest we die" (20:19).
10. Moses says, "Do not fear, for God has come to test you, that the fear of him may be before you, that you may not sin" (20:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Look at the order. In chapter 19, before a single commandment is given, God reminds Israel of what he has done: "You have seen…how I bore you on eagles' wings and brought you to myself.' The same pattern is in 20:2. The commandments begin with a statement of redemption, "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery." This is the key to the entire law. It is not a ladder by which slaves climb to freedom. It is the way of life for people who have already been freed. This is the pattern of grace establishing law, and it is the theme of the unit.

God's description of Israel in 19:5-6 is breathtaking. "My treasured possession." "A kingdom of priests and a holy nation." They are chosen out of all the peoples, set apart, and given a mission. They are to be priests, mediating between God and the nations. The New Testament will apply this same language to the church (1 Peter 2:9).

The people respond with eagerness: "All that the LORD has spoken we will do." It is a sincere answer, and it is a disastrously overconfident one. They have not yet understood what they promised. Within forty days they will be dancing around a golden calf. It is one of the key tragedies of the Old Testament: the people said yes without understanding the cost.

The scene at the mountain is meant to communicate holiness. The boundaries, the fire, the smoke, the thunder, and the trumpet all say the same thing: God is not safe. The people are frightened, and rightly so. Their request that Moses speak for them is a request for a mediator. God approves it in Deuteronomy 18:17. A mediator will stand between them and the holy God. This points forward to Christ.

The Ten Commandments themselves are a summary of what it means to love God and love your neighbor. The first four concern God: his exclusive worship, his image, his name, and his day. The last six concern people: family, life, marriage, property, truth, and the heart's desire. The tenth, "You shall not covet," is the one that goes deepest, because it is about what the heart wants, and no human court can enforce it.

Moses' last word at the end of the chapter is a paradox. "Do not fear...that the fear of him may be before you." There is a fear that is terror, and a fear that is reverence. God does not want his people to cower. He wants them to stand in awe.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus summarized the law as love for God and love for neighbor (Matthew 22:37-40). Hebrews 12:18-24 contrasts Mount Sinai, the mountain of fear, with Mount Zion, where we come to "Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant." Peter calls the church "a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession" (1 Peter 2:9). Paul says that the law was "added because of transgressions" (Galatians 3:19), pointing to Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Say the Ten Commandments aloud, or read them slowly, and ask which one most clearly shows your need of grace. Do not rush through this step.

Notice that the first words are not "You shall" but "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out." Receive that sentence as a statement about you if you are in Christ.

Think about how you tend to say "all that the LORD has spoken we will do" without counting the cost. Ask God for a humble and honest heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he redeems before he commands.

Tell him where you find his commands hard.

Thank Jesus for keeping the law you could not.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

“The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father’s God, and I will exalt him.”

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 111 · WEEK 16

Exodus 20:1-17; Matthew 5:17-48; Romans 13:8-10

The Moral Law and the Christian

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 20:1-17, Matthew 5:17-48, and Romans 13:8-10. The first is the Ten Commandments, the second is Jesus' teaching about the law in the Sermon on the Mount, and the third is Paul's summary of the law as love. Read them in order, and ask how each one relates to the others.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second doctrinal pause in Unit 5, and it raises one of the most important questions in the Christian life: what is the place of the law for someone who is saved by grace? Christians have debated this for two thousand years. Some say that Christ has abolished the law. Others say that it applies to us just as it did to Israel. The answer, as usual, is in between, and it takes careful reading. You are not under the law as a way of earning salvation, and yet the law still matters. This day will help you see how.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The Ten Commandments begin with grace: "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt" (Exodus 20:2).
2. Jesus says, "Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them" (Matthew 5:17).
3. "Until heaven and earth pass away, not an iota or a dot will pass from the Law until all is accomplished" (5:18).
4. Jesus teaches six times, "You have heard that it was said…But I say to you" (5:21, 27, 31, 33, 38, 43).

5. On murder: “Everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment” (5:22). On adultery: “Everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart” (5:28).
6. He ends: “You therefore must be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect” (5:48).
7. Paul writes, “Owe no one anything, except to love each other, for the one who loves another has fulfilled the law” (Romans 13:8).
8. The commandments “are summed up in this word: You shall love your neighbor as yourself” (13:9). “Love is the fulfilling of the law” (13:10).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Christians have long spoken of three uses of the law, a framework that goes back to the Reformation. The first use is civil or political. The law restrains evil in society by setting boundaries and threatening punishment. Paul says that the law is “not laid down for the just but for the lawless and disobedient” (1 Timothy 1:9). The second use is pedagogical, or evangelical. The law shows us our sin and drives us to Christ. Paul writes, “Through the law comes knowledge of sin” (Romans 3:20), and “the law was our guardian until Christ came, in order that we might be justified by faith” (Galatians 3:24). The third use is for believers: the law shows what a life that pleases God looks like. It guides the redeemed to live as the redeemed.

You can see all three at work in Exodus 19 and 20. The commandments restrain a violent and idolatrous people. They also expose sin, as the people’s quick fall into idolatry proves. And they tell a freed people how to live as God’s people. All three uses are present.

How does this fit with the New Testament? Here the Bible’s own storyline matters. The law given at Sinai was a covenant with Israel, with its own sanctions, rituals, and civil laws. The New Testament teaches that Christians are no longer “under the law” in that sense (Romans 6:14; Galatians 3:25). The Mosaic covenant, as a covenant, has been fulfilled and replaced by the new covenant (Hebrews 8:13). This means that we do not keep the sacrificial system, the food laws, or the civil code of ancient Israel. They pointed to Christ, and he has accomplished what they signified.

But this does not mean that the moral will of God has changed. Jesus says that he came to fulfill the law, not to abolish it. He fulfilled it in several ways: by obeying it perfectly, by bearing its penalty, by fulfilling what it pointed to, and by revealing its deepest meaning. In the Sermon on the Mount, he shows that the commandments reach the heart: not just murder but anger, not just adultery but lust. The moral core of the Ten Commandments is

reaffirmed in the New Testament, though now seen in the light of Christ, and nine of the ten are repeated explicitly (the fourth, about the Sabbath, is applied in a distinctive way through the rest we have in Christ, as in Hebrews 4:9-10 and Colossians 2:16-17).

The new covenant also gives something the old could not: a new heart. Jeremiah promised, "I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts" (Jeremiah 31:33). This is the power of the Spirit. The law still shows us what God desires, but now the Spirit enables us to love it. Paul calls this "the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2), the law of love as lived and taught by Jesus.

That is why Paul can say in Romans 13 that love fulfills the law. He does not mean that love replaces the commandments. He means that love is what the commandments were pointing to all along. If you love your neighbor, you will not murder, steal, or covet. The law is not a list of rules to be checked. It is a description of what love does.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Pay attention to what Jesus does in Matthew 5. He does not loosen the law. He tightens it. Anger is a kind of murder. Lust is a kind of adultery. This is not meant to crush his hearers into despair, though it does that for anyone honest. It is meant to show that the standard is perfection, "as your heavenly Father is perfect." No one can meet that standard. The law is a mirror that shows us what we are.

But this is where the good news comes in. If you cannot keep the law, you need someone who has. Jesus lived a life of perfect obedience, and he gives it to those who trust in him. In 2 Corinthians 5:21, Paul says, "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God." Our standing before God is based on his obedience, not ours.

And once you are in Christ, the law takes on a new character. It is no longer a threat. It is a guide. It describes the kind of life that the Spirit is producing in you. This is why Paul can say both that we are not under the law and that we fulfill its requirement (Romans 8:4). The one who is saved by grace wants to obey.

The structure of Exodus 20 should be remembered. Grace comes first: "I brought you out." Then law: "You shall." This is the order of the gospel. We obey because we have been saved, not in order to be saved.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:3-4 says that "God has done what the law, weakened by the flesh, could not do...in order that the righteous requirement of the law might be fulfilled in us, who walk not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit." Galatians 5:14 says, "For the whole law is fulfilled in one word: You shall love your neighbor as yourself." James 2:8-12 calls it "the royal law" and "the law of liberty." Hebrews 8:10 quotes Jeremiah 31 about the law written on the heart.

STEP 6

Application

Read the Sermon on the Mount slowly this week. Ask the Spirit to show you where your heart does not match the standard, and bring that to Christ.

Choose one commandment to meditate on, and ask how a person who loves God and neighbor would keep it in your situation this week.

Thank God for the new heart he has given you, and ask him to increase your delight in his commands.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that the law shows your need and drives you to Christ.
- Ask the Spirit to write his law on your heart.
- Ask for a love for God and neighbor that comes from the heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 16

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

DAY 112 · WEEK 16

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Exodus 15:2 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him."

EXODUS 15:2

REST

Meditation

Exodus 15:2 is the first personal confession of faith in the Bible's story of redemption. It comes from the lips of a freed people standing on the shore of the sea, and it is as true today as it was then.

"The LORD is my strength." They have just seen what happened when they tried to rely on their own strength in Egypt: nothing. Now they have seen what he can do. Notice the possessive: not "the LORD is strong" but "the LORD is my strength." The strength of God becomes the strength of his people. When you are weak, as you often are, this is your resource.

"And my song." This is one of the loveliest phrases in Scripture. God is not only the source of strength but the reason for singing. A person who has been rescued does not just survive. They sing. If you find yourself without a song, one remedy is to remember what he has done.

“And he has become my salvation.” This is the center. The word is yeshuah, the root of the name Jesus. God himself is the salvation. He is not just the one who gives a rescue. He is the rescue. The same is true of Jesus: he does not merely point to a way of salvation. He is the way.

“This is my God, and I will praise him.” Faith is personal. It is not enough to know about God. The goal is to say “my God.” “My father’s God, and I will exalt him.” And faith is generational. The God of the fathers has become the God of the children.

For the Christian, the verse is a daily prayer. In Christ, the LORD is your strength, your song, and your salvation.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw the exodus completed and the journey to Sinai begun. You read Moses’ song, the first song of redemption, and then watched the people turn to complaining at Marah. You prayed three psalms about the exodus: Psalm 77, where the psalmist remembered the deeds of God in his distress, and Psalm 114, where the earth trembled before the God who brought Israel out. You followed Israel through hunger and the gift of manna, through thirst and water from the rock, and through the battle with Amalek, where Moses’ hands were held up by Aaron and Hur. Then you came to Sinai. You heard God describe Israel as a kingdom of priests and a holy nation, and you read the Ten Commandments, which begin with the words, “I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt.” On the doctrinal day, you considered the three uses of the law and how the law relates to the Christian. The week taught that God redeems before he commands, and that the law shows us our need for grace.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Moses sang, “The LORD is my strength and my song.” What is the song you are singing right now? If you are in a season without a song, what would it take to remember what God has done?

How does it change your reading of the Ten Commandments to know that they begin with “I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt”? How does Christ’s fulfillment of the law affect the way you obey it?

Think of a time when you asked, “Is the LORD among us or not?” How did God answer? Write about how he has shown himself to be present with you, and thank him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he redeems before he commands.

Thank Christ for fulfilling the law for you.

Rest in him, and ask him to teach you to love his commandments.

DAY 113 · WEEK 17

Exodus 21:1-22:31

The Book of the Covenant, case laws

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 21:1-22:31. These two chapters contain the first set of laws that follow the Ten Commandments. They can feel foreign and sometimes hard. Read them slowly, and ask what each law shows about God's concern for justice, for the vulnerable, and for human life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the Ten Commandments, God gives Moses a long set of specific rulings called the Book of the Covenant (Exodus 20:22-23:33). They are case laws, applications of the broad principles of the Ten Commandments to the daily life of an agricultural society in the ancient Near East. This is not the part of the Bible that most new readers enjoy. But it is worth reading carefully, because it shows how God cares about the details of everyday justice. The laws also come to us in a particular covenant with Israel at a particular time, and reading them well means knowing how they fit the whole story.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first law concerns Hebrew servants: "When you buy a Hebrew slave, he shall serve six years, and in the seventh he shall go out free, for nothing" (21:2).
2. Kidnapping is a capital crime: "Whoever steals a man and sells him, and anyone found in possession of him, shall be put to death" (21:16).
3. Laws on injury include the principle, "You shall pay life for life, eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot" (21:23-24).
4. If a slave is injured by a master, the slave is to go free (21:26-27).

5. If an ox gores someone, the owner is held responsible if he knew it was dangerous (21:28-36).
6. Laws on theft and restitution require thieves to repay several times over (22:1-4).
7. "You shall not wrong a sojourner or oppress him, for you were sojourners in the land of Egypt" (22:21).
8. "You shall not afflict any widow or fatherless child. If you do afflict them…my wrath will burn" (22:22-24).
9. "If you lend money to my people, to the poor among you, you shall not be to him as a moneylender, and you shall not exact interest from him" (22:25).
10. "If ever you take your neighbor's cloak in pledge, you shall return it to him before the sun goes down…for when he cries to me, I will hear, for I am compassionate" (22:26-27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to understand is the way these laws are written. They are case laws: "If a man does this, then this is the consequence." They are not an exhaustive legal code. They are examples that train judges to think about justice. The laws are also specific to the setting of ancient Israel. Modern readers sometimes want to treat every verse as a rule for today, or else dismiss the whole thing as irrelevant. Neither is right. The better approach is to ask what each law reveals about God's character, and how the principle is fulfilled in Christ.

Take the opening law about servants. It may trouble modern readers, and the questions are fair. Slavery is a hard subject, and the Bible does not hide from it. But look at what the law actually does. The servitude it describes is a form of debt labor, limited to six years, with release in the seventh. Kidnapping and selling a person is punished by death. Injury to a slave sets the slave free. In a world where slaves were property without rights, the law gives human beings dignity and protection. It does not describe the ideal. It restrains the worst. The deeper message, "You were sojourners in Egypt," appeals to the exodus. Israel is to remember that they were slaves once, and that the LORD set them free.

The "eye for eye" principle is easy to misread. In its original setting, it is a limit, not a license for revenge. The punishment must fit the crime and go no further. This protects against escalating retaliation. Jesus will take the principle deeper in Matthew 5:38-39, telling his followers to renounce personal revenge: "If anyone slaps you on the right cheek, turn to him the other also." He is not abolishing the court's duty to do justice. He is calling individuals to a higher way of living.

The most striking pattern in these chapters is the care for the weak. The sojourner, the widow, the orphan, and the poor borrower are all named. God says that when they cry out, "I will surely hear their cry" (22:23). The God who heard the cry of Israel in Egypt now commands Israel to hear the cry of the vulnerable. His justice is shaped by his own experience of redeeming slaves. The cloak law is a gem: a poor man's coat, taken as a pledge, must be returned by nightfall, because he needs it to sleep in. And the reason given is simply: "for I am compassionate."

Paul shows how to read these laws in light of Christ in 1 Corinthians 9:9-10. He quotes the law, "You shall not muzzle an ox when it treads out the grain," and applies it to paying ministers. He sees in the law a principle of fairness that goes beyond the particular case. We are to read the case laws as windows into the heart of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that the greatest in the kingdom would be the servant of all (Mark 10:43-45). Paul's letter to Philemon asks a master to receive his runaway slave "no longer as a bondservant but more than a bondservant, as a beloved brother" (Philemon 16). James 1:27 says that "religion that is pure and undefiled before God" is "to visit orphans and widows in their affliction." Leviticus 19:33-34 repeats the command to love the sojourner.

STEP 6

Application

Read the laws on the vulnerable in 22:21-27 again. Who are the sojourners, widows, orphans, and poor borrowers in your community? Choose one action this week to help one of them.

Practice reading hard passages by asking what they reveal about God's character. Write down one thing you learn about God from today's reading.

Thank God that he is compassionate, and let that shape the way you treat people who owe you something.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give you his heart for the stranger, the widow, and the orphan.

Ask him for humility as you read his law.

Tell him where you are asking Christ to show you more.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

“And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst.”

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 114 · WEEK 17

Exodus 23:1-24:18

Covenant concluded; the Sabbath; ratification with blood

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Exodus 23:1-24:18. The first part finishes the Book of the Covenant with laws on justice, the Sabbath, and the feasts. The second part, chapter 24, describes the ratification of the covenant with blood. Read chapter 24 slowly. It is one of the most important chapters in the Old Testament.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The laws of the Book of the Covenant are almost finished. Now Moses goes down to the people, and the covenant between God and Israel is formally sealed. This is like a wedding ceremony or a treaty ratification. There is a reading of the terms, a public promise by the people, a sacrifice, and a meal. Then Moses is called back up the mountain for forty days to receive instructions for the tabernacle. This is the end of the first half of Exodus, and the unit's closing scene.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "You shall not fall in with the many to do wrong, nor shall you bear witness in a lawsuit, siding with the many, so as to pervert justice" (23:2).
2. "If you meet your enemy's ox or his donkey going astray, you shall bring it back to him" (23:4).
3. "You shall not oppress a sojourner. You know the heart of a sojourner, for you were sojourners in the land of Egypt" (23:9).
4. "Six days you shall do your work, but on the seventh day you shall rest" (23:12). The land too is to rest every seventh year (23:10-11).

5. Three times a year, all males are to appear before the LORD at the feasts of unleavened bread, harvest, and ingathering (23:14-17).
6. God promises to send an angel before them, "for my name is in him" (23:20-21).
7. Moses writes down all the words of the LORD and builds an altar with twelve pillars. The people say, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do, and we will be obedient" (24:3-7).
8. Moses takes half the blood and throws it against the altar, and the other half he sprinkles on the people, saying, "Behold the blood of the covenant that the LORD has made with you in accordance with all these words" (24:6-8).
9. Moses, Aaron, Nadab, Abihu, and seventy elders go up and "saw the God of Israel…they beheld God, and ate and drank" (24:9-11).
10. Moses goes up the mountain with Joshua, and the glory of the LORD rests on it like "a devouring fire" for forty days and forty nights (24:13-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The laws at the start of chapter 23 are some of the most practical in the Bible. They tell the truth in court, even when the crowd is against you. They tell you to help an enemy's animal in trouble. They forbid taking bribes. The standards are high and they touch real life. The line "You shall not fall in with the many to do wrong" is a good motto for a believer in any age. The right thing and the popular thing are not always the same.

Most striking is the repeated appeal to Israel's own experience. "You know the heart of a sojourner." The law is built on empathy: you have been where they are, so treat them as God treated you. This is the way the Bible teaches ethics. It asks people to remember grace and then to act like people who have received it.

Now to chapter 24, which is the most significant. The covenant is sealed with blood. This is the second great blood ritual in the book, after the Passover. At the Passover, the blood protected Israel from judgment. Here, the blood binds Israel to God in covenant. Half is thrown on the altar, which represents God, and half is sprinkled on the people. Both parties are bound together by the blood. "Behold the blood of the covenant." These are words that Jesus will echo at the Last Supper.

The promise of the people, "All that the LORD has spoken we will do, and we will be obedient," is sincere. But as you saw earlier, they will break it within weeks. The covenant is real, and the people are weak. This tension, between God's holy demands and human

inability, runs through the whole Old Testament and creates the longing for a better covenant.

The scene on the mountain in verses 9 to 11 is one of the most mysterious in the Bible. Leaders of Israel see the God of Israel. They see "under his feet as it were a pavement of sapphire stone, like the very heaven for clearness." It is a glimpse of the throne room of God. And, astonishingly, "God did not lay his hand on them. They beheld God, and ate and drank." They share a meal in his presence. This is a preview of the fellowship that is the goal of the covenant, and it will be fulfilled when God's people eat and drink with him in the kingdom.

The unit ends with Moses entering the cloud. The glory looks like a devouring fire. God is both near and dangerous, and Moses will be gone for forty days.

STEP 5

Connection

At the Last Supper, Jesus took the cup and said, "This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (Matthew 26:28), echoing Exodus 24:8. Hebrews 9:18-22 explains that the first covenant was inaugurated with blood and that Christ's blood inaugurates a better one. The meal on the mountain points to the marriage supper of the Lamb (Revelation 19:9). Peter says that believers are "sprinkled with his blood" (1 Peter 1:2).

STEP 6

Application

When you take the Lord's Supper, hear the words of Exodus 24:8 behind the words of Jesus. You are being brought into a covenant sealed with blood.

Think about where you tend to "fall in with the many." Ask God for courage to stand for what is right.

Remember what it was like to be a stranger or an outsider in a new church, a new job, or a new town. Reach out to someone who is new this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the blood that sealed the covenant for you.

Ask for courage to do right when the crowd does wrong.

Ask him to teach you kindness to strangers.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

“And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst.”

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 115 · WEEK 17

Psalm 105:26-45

Moses and Aaron sent; the plagues recounted

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 105:26-45. This is the exodus story told as praise. Compare it in your mind to Psalm 106, which you read earlier in the unit. The two psalms tell the same history from opposite sides.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 105 and Psalm 106 are a pair. Psalm 106 tells the story of Israel's failures. Psalm 105 tells the story of God's faithfulness. This psalm begins by calling Israel to thank the LORD and make his deeds known among the peoples, and then it traces the history from Abraham to the conquest. Today you read the section about the exodus, and it is a fitting way to end Unit 5, since it summarizes everything you have just read and gives the reason for it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He sent Moses his servant, and Aaron, whom he had chosen" (v. 26).
2. "They performed his signs among them and miracles in the land of Ham" (v. 27).
3. The plagues are recounted: darkness, blood, frogs, flies, gnats, hail, locusts, and the death of the firstborn (vv. 28-36).
4. "Then he brought out Israel with silver and gold, and there was none among his tribes who stumbled" (v. 37).
5. "Egypt was glad when they departed, for dread of them had fallen upon it" (v. 38).
6. "He spread a cloud for a covering, and fire to give light by night" (v. 39).
7. "They asked, and he brought quail, and gave them bread from heaven in abundance" (v. 40).

8. “He opened the rock, and water gushed out; it flowed through the desert like a river” (v. 41).
9. “For he remembered his holy promise, and Abraham, his servant” (v. 42).
10. “So he brought his people out with joy, his chosen ones with singing” (v. 43).
11. He gave them the lands of the nations “that they might keep his statutes and observe his laws. Praise the LORD!” (vv. 44-45).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 105 is a retelling of the exodus with all the failures left out. This is not dishonest. It is a different purpose. Psalm 106 is a confession. Psalm 105 is a thanksgiving. Both are true. The Bible does not hide Israel’s sin, and it does not let sin have the last word.

Notice first who the main actor is. “He sent Moses.” “He brought out Israel.” “He spread a cloud.” “He brought quail.” “He opened the rock.” In the whole passage, God is the subject of almost every verb. Israel is the object. The psalmist is retelling the exodus as a story of what God did. That is the right way to read it. The story is not primarily about Moses’ courage or Israel’s faith. It is about God’s power and faithfulness.

The reason is given in verse 42: “For he remembered his holy promise, and Abraham, his servant.” This verse is the key to the whole book of Exodus. In 2:24, God heard their groaning and remembered his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Here, centuries later, the psalmist says the same: he remembered. The exodus was not a rescue of convenience. It was the fulfillment of a promise made generations before.

Verse 37 is a nice detail. “There was none among his tribes who stumbled.” The whole company of Israel, old, young, sick, and weak, walked out of Egypt without anyone falling behind. God’s redemption is complete. No one is lost.

The ending sets out the purpose of the entire exodus. God gave them the land “that they might keep his statutes and observe his laws.” This brings you back to Sinai. The goal of redemption is a people who obey. This is not to earn the redemption but to live as the redeemed. And the response to all of it is the one word that closes the psalm: “Praise the LORD!”

Placed here, at the end of the unit, the psalm looks forward as well. The God who remembered Abraham and kept his word to Israel will remember his covenant again and send a greater redeemer.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 1:72-73 sings the same note at the birth of Jesus: God "has remembered his holy covenant, the oath that he swore to our father Abraham." Peter says that Christ's death was foreknown and planned (1 Peter 1:18-20). Hebrews 2:15 says Christ came "to deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong slavery." Revelation 15 and 16 echo the plagues and the song of Moses.

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of ways God has been faithful to a promise in your life or in the life of your church. Praise him for each one.

Notice how the psalm ends with obedience. Ask what a response of gratitude would look like in your daily choices.

Say the last word of the psalm out loud: "Praise the LORD!" Do it at least once today, on purpose.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for being faithful to every word he has spoken.
- Thank him for the greater exodus in Jesus.
- Ask him to help you keep his statutes out of gratitude.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 17

"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst."

EXODUS 25:8

DAY 116 · WEEK 17

Review and Reflection

Unit 5 review, The Mosaic Covenant I, Exodus

Year 1 · Unit 5 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery."
>
> EXODUS 20:2

REST

Meditation

Exodus 20:2 is the opening line of the Ten Commandments, and it is the unit's anchor verse. It is easy to skip over it on the way to the commands, but it is the most important sentence in the chapter. Read it aloud once more before you continue.

"I am the LORD your God." The sentence begins with a name and a relationship. God is the LORD, the covenant God who revealed himself at the burning bush. And he is "your God." Before there is any command, there is a claim: I belong to you, and you belong to me.

"Who brought you out of the land of Egypt." This is the basis of the claim. God has already acted. He rescued them when they could not rescue themselves. The authority of the commandments rests on his grace.

"Out of the house of slavery." It is a wonderful phrase. Egypt was a house, a place of confinement and hard labor, and God brought them out. The rest of the commandments describe what life looks like for people who have been freed. They are no longer slaves, so they do not need to act like slaves, and they are no longer under Pharaoh, so they do not serve other gods.

For the Christian, the verse is a statement about Christ. He is the one who has brought us out of the house of slavery, the slavery to sin and death. "For freedom Christ has set us free" (Galatians 5:1). Obedience is the grateful response of those who have been rescued.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 5 you have read the first half of the book of Exodus, from the birth of Moses to the ratification of the covenant at Sinai. You began with Israel in slavery and with Pharaoh's attempt to destroy the Hebrew sons, and you watched God preserve a baby in a basket. At the burning bush, God revealed his name, I AM WHO I AM, and sent a reluctant Moses to bring his people out. On your first doctrinal day, you studied the existence and attributes of God, from his self-existence to the character of mercy and justice that he proclaimed in Exodus 34.

You followed the confrontation with Pharaoh. The plagues, one after another, were judgments on the gods of Egypt and demonstrations of who the LORD is. You watched Pharaoh bargain and harden his heart. Then came the Passover: a lamb without blemish, its blood on the doorposts, and the promise, "When I see the blood, I will pass over you." You walked through the Red Sea on dry ground and heard Moses say, "The LORD will fight for you." You sang the song of Moses and watched the song give way to grumbling at Marah. You prayed through three psalms of the exodus, and saw how the Psalms use the story as a resource for confession, for memory in distress, and for praise.

In the wilderness, God gave manna, water from the rock, and victory over Amalek. At Sinai, God described Israel as a kingdom of priests and a holy nation, and he gave the Ten Commandments, beginning with the words, "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out." On your second doctrinal day, you studied the three uses of the law and how the moral law relates to the Christian. You read the case laws of the Book of the Covenant and saw God's care for the sojourner, the widow, and the orphan. Finally, you watched the covenant sealed with blood, and the elders eat and drink in the presence of God.

The unit taught that God redeems before he commands, that the blood of the substitute is the ground of safety, and that the exodus is a pattern for all of God's saving work.

REFLECT

Review Questions

Why does it matter that God redeems Israel before giving them the law at Sinai?

Look back at Exodus 19:4 and 20:2. God reminded Israel of what he had done before he told them what to do. How does this order protect us from thinking that we earn salvation by obedience? Write a few sentences about how it changes the way you think about the commands of God in your own life.

What does the Passover reveal about the nature of atonement?

Think about the lamb without blemish, the blood on the doorposts, and the promise, "When I see the blood, I will pass over you." What does this teach about substitution and about how God's judgment and mercy meet? How does it help you understand the death of Jesus?

What are the three uses of the law, and can you find each one in Exodus?

Recall the civil, the pedagogical, and the normative uses. Where do you see the law restraining a violent people, exposing sin, and guiding the redeemed? Which use do you find most helpful for your own growth, and which do you tend to forget?

How does the Exodus function as a pattern for all of God's saving work?

Consider the slavery, the rescue by a mediator, the blood, the passage through water, the covenant, and the journey toward a promised land. Where do you see these themes fulfilled in Christ? Write a short prayer of thanks to Jesus for the greater exodus he has accomplished.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the exodus and for the greater exodus in Christ.

Ask him to teach you to obey out of gratitude.

Ask him to keep the unit verse near you.